

SAFETY- AND EMERGENCY-RELATED COMMUNICATIONS

Loudoun County Public Schools' ("LCPS") highest priority is the safety and security of students and staff. Building strong partnerships with families and the community is one of the Division's core beliefs. When emergencies or unusual incidents occur at a school or other LCPS facility, event or activity, it is important that the Division initiate a coordinated response that engages all appropriate resources to provide timely and accurate communication with affected communities.

While LCPS administrators are trained to manage emergencies and unusual incidents and every school has a school-specific Emergency Response Plan that outlines the school's operational response to critical incidents, the Division believes that building and maintaining trust with the public relies on its ability to meet clear expectations about communications during emergencies or unusual incidents.

The goal of this policy is to provide definitions for terminology used in communications about safety- and emergency-related incidents and to outline how the Division will generally communicate when emergency or unusual incidents occur.

A. Definitions

1. Emergency or Unusual Incident(s). Any occurrence that disrupts the normal school day or any LCPS schedule, program, event, or activity, and which could involve risk of injury to students, visitors or staff, or any other unusual occurrence that threatens the safety and security of students, staff or LCPS property. Such incidents may include, but are not limited to, events that would result in activity restrictions, scheduling delays, transportation delays, or the unusual presence or activity by emergency personnel (e.g. police, fire, EMS, ambulance) at a LCPS facility, event or activity.

2. Hold. A temporary maintenance of students and staff in place, usually in classrooms. This is done to allow staff time to gather further information or allow a situation to resolve itself. A medical emergency in a hallway is an example of an incident that may require this action.

3. Lockdown. Enhanced security measures taken to protect against potentially violent intruders that may be inside a school or on a school campus. During a lockdown, students, visitors, and staff are secured, usually in classrooms, to prevent access or harm to the occupants of the building. Lockdown may also involve moving students, visitors and staff from unsecured locations to secure locations or otherwise away from the threat. Only a law enforcement officer can release a school from a lockdown.

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4. Secure the Building. Preventive measures taken to preclude unauthorized entry to a school or facility if there is a potential threat external to the facility. Examples of such threats include a police foot chase near a school, a wild animal on campus, or other criminal activity in geographical proximity to the building. Once a building is secured by staff or law enforcement, all outside activities are cancelled, and any students and staff who may be outside the facility are instructed to move inside. All visitors and deliveries are initially declined when a building is secured and school dismissals may be delayed. Only staff, with guidance from public safety officials, can release a school from being secured.

5. Shelter in Place. Procedures used to temporarily shelter people from a hazardous outdoor atmosphere, such as weather, chemical, biological, or radiological threats. During this scenario, all exterior doors remain locked, and measures may be taken to shut down the intake of external air. During Shelter in Place, no one is allowed to enter the school or facility until public safety officials (law enforcement, fire or public health officials, depending on the type of incident) declare the area safe.

6. Evacuate. During situations where a building has become or could become uninhabitable, occupants are directed to leave the school or facility. Examples include a fire, chemical spill, or gas leak. During an evacuation, all students, visitors and staff will relocate to a pre-determined location. Once at that location, a decision will be made whether or not to evacuate to a secondary location further from the incident.

B. Information to be Provided. When an emergency or unusual event occurs at a school, LCPS facility, event, or activity, the Division Superintendent or designee will provide factual information about the event on a timely basis to students, parents/guardians, staff, the LCPS School Board, and the public. Information provided will comply with all applicable federal and state laws, as well as with LCPS practices regarding the privacy of students and staff. In situations involving law enforcement or other civil agencies, LCPS will communicate in a manner that avoids compromising an emergency response, investigation, or fact-gathering by those agencies. Based on facts that are available, and consistent with other constraints described in Sections C, D, and E of this policy, information LCPS shares will include:

1. the nature and characteristic(s) of the incident;
2. how the incident is expected to impact students, staff, and the public;
3. which schools or other facilities are affected;
4. whether and how law enforcement, emergency services, or other civil agencies are involved;

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5. any safety measures being put in place in response to the incident to the extent that communicating these measures would not further or additionally compromise student and staff safety;

6. a timeframe for future communications;

7. which communities are receiving communications; and

8. other details that can assist stakeholders in evaluating the impact of the incident.

C. Factors in Determining Information Distribution. In determining the content and distribution plans for announcements about emergencies or unusual incidents, LCPS will consider which school communities should be notified. To the extent permitted by law, LCPS shall provide as much relevant information as permissible to community members regarding safety and security incidents that take place on LCPS property or at LCPS school-sponsored activities or events. Factors that will be considered include:

1. the scope and impact of the incident on the immediate and adjacent communities;

2. proximity of other schools to the site of the incident;

3. potential perceptions of risk by adjacent communities; and

4. other information that may be available.

D. Limits on Information Distribution. Information will be provided consistent with the privacy limits established by federal and state laws and regulations and LCPS policies and practices. These limits include, but are not limited to, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA), a federal law that prohibits disclosure of education records without parental consent except in certain circumstances; exemptions from the Virginia Freedom of Information Act (VFOIA), which may permit the Division to retain certain information; Loudoun County School Board Policy 8640, Disclosure of Personally Identifiable Information; and Loudoun County School Board Policy 7306, Personnel Records. Other LCPS policies and practices may also inhibit the Division from disclosing information. Prior to the release of any safety- and emergency-related communications related to student privacy, Division Counsel shall be consulted to ensure that confidential, or otherwise private, information is withheld in accordance with applicable law.

Limits on the disclosure of information may also include unique or complicating characteristics of an incident as well as input from law enforcement or other civil agencies.

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E. Coordination with Law Enforcement and Other Civil Agencies. Information that relates to incidents involving law enforcement or other civil agencies will be coordinated with those agencies in advance of any public release of information. LCPS will avoid interfering with investigations by law enforcement or other civil agencies related to incidents that may involve allegations of criminal behavior.

F. Coordination Among School and Division Administrators. The Division Superintendent, Division Counsel, Communications and Community Engagement Office, other designated staff, and school Principals may have a role in communicating about emergencies and unusual incidents. These administrators will work collaboratively to determine the nature, scope, timing, and approval of communications about emergencies and unusual incidents.

G. Communications Channels. LCPS uses a variety of channels to communicate information about emergencies or unusual events, including but not limited to:

1. direct emails, texts, phone calls, or other messages to students, parents/guardians and staff;
2. posts to social media sites;
3. announcements on the Division website or individual school websites,
4. releases of information to local news media outlets; and
5. other means that may be helpful in ensuring that information is provided to the intended audiences.

In most situations, LCPS will use automated email messages sent through the Division's mass notification system to communicate timely information about unusual incidents.

For events that result in schedule changes during the academic day, either at a single school or at multiple schools, LCPS also may use text messages and automated phone calls, in addition to email messages to communicate current information on a timely basis. LCPS also may use announcements on social media, through LCPS websites or to area news media to communicate that information.

The Division Superintendent will publish regulations to govern the application of this policy, including information that describes the communications channels that LCPS would use in various circumstances to convey information to parents, guardians, and the public, as well as intended audiences and timing thereof.

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Cross Refs: Policy [8640](#), Disclosure of Personally Identifiable Information
Policy [7306](#), Personnel Records.